

Module 8: Migration Journey and Experience

Graduate Research Project

Caring for the Journey: How Providers Use Trauma-Informed Frameworks

Overview

A qualitative study interviewing service providers (not survivors) about how trauma-informed care frameworks guide — and where they fail — their work with people who have experienced difficult migration journeys.

Aligned learning outcomes

- Evaluate trauma-informed frameworks (Grad 1)
- Apply ethical engagement principles in research design (Grad 2)

Sample research questions

- How do frontline providers translate trauma-informed principles into daily practice with newcomers?
- Where do standard frameworks fit poorly — cultural assumptions, gendered experiences, children's needs?
- What adaptations have practitioners developed that the literature hasn't captured?

Methods

Semi-structured interviews with 4–6 providers (caseworkers, clinicians, program staff), thematically coded, analyzed against published trauma-informed care frameworks (e.g., SAMHSA principles) and the refugee mental health literature. Interviewing providers rather than survivors is a deliberate ethical design choice.

IRB / research ethics

REQUIRED. Submit before any recruitment; provider interviews typically qualify for expedited review. Include consent forms and de-identification plan.

Deliverables

- IRB protocol (graded milestone)
- 4,500-word qualitative analysis with coded themes
- Practitioner-facing summary of findings (1–2 pages)

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Ethical rigor of the design and IRB protocol 25%	Conduct is impeccable: ethical rigor of the design and IRB protocol is demonstrated throughout, protocols are followed without exception, and the work shows active care for the people and communities involved.	Conduct is sound: ethical rigor of the design and IRB protocol is evident with only minor lapses that do not affect participants or partners, and all required protocols are followed.	Conduct is uneven: ethical rigor of the design and IRB protocol is addressed but with gaps — a missed protocol step, careless handling of sensitive material, or boundary issues requiring instructor follow-up.	Conduct falls short of requirements: ethical rigor of the design and IRB protocol is neglected in ways that required intervention or placed participants, partners, or material at risk.
Interview and coding quality 30%	Method is rigorous and transparent: interview and coding quality is fully documented, choices are justified, limitations are stated, and another student could replicate the work from what is written.	Method is sound: interview and coding quality is documented and mostly justified, with limitations acknowledged; small gaps would not change the findings.	Method is partial: interview and coding quality is described but under-documented or inconsistently applied, leaving findings plausible but not checkable.	Method is absent or unsound: interview and coding quality is missing, undocumented, or applied so loosely that the findings cannot be trusted.
Critical evaluation of frameworks against field reality 30%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: critical evaluation of frameworks against field reality goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: critical evaluation of frameworks against field reality is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: critical evaluation of frameworks against field reality is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: critical evaluation of frameworks against field reality is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Practitioner summary usefulness 15%	The deliverable is excellent: practitioner summary usefulness is met at a standard the partner or audience can use immediately — complete, accurate, well-organized, and genuinely useful.	The deliverable is good: practitioner summary usefulness is met; it is usable with minor revisions and its purpose is clearly served.	The deliverable is incomplete: practitioner summary usefulness is only partly met — gaps, errors, or unclear organization mean substantial revision is needed before it could be used.	The deliverable is inadequate: practitioner summary usefulness is not met; the product is unusable, inaccurate, or missing major required elements.